SOCIAL PSYCHOLOGY

The Psychology of Interpersonal Relations

Fritz Heider · 1958

A founding text of social psychology. Heider studied the everyday, common-sense theories we all use to explain why other people do what they do.[1,2]

WHY READ IT

- The source of ideas you'll meet everywhere in psychology and design[2]
- A deep look at how we perceive and judge each other[2]
- A classic that rewards slow, careful reading[2]

GET THE BOOK

🤝 **The Psychology of Interpersonal Relations** by Fritz Heider
John Wiley & Sons, 1958. At your local bookshop, your library, or as an audiobook.

A free guide inspired by *The Psychology of Interpersonal Relations* by Fritz Heider. Not affiliated with the author or publisher.

Please read the book

THE BIG IDEA

We are all intuitive psychologists

We constantly guess at the causes of other people's behavior, and those guesses shape how we treat them. Heider noticed we lean toward explaining others by who they are rather than the situation they're in. Later researchers named that tilt the fundamental attribution error.[2,3]

THREE LESSONS

1. **Naive psychology**
   Ordinary people have working theories about each other's minds. Heider took those theories seriously as a subject of study.[2]

2. **We see intentions everywhere**
   In an earlier study with Marianne Simmel, people watching moving shapes described them as having goals and personalities.[2,4]

3. **Relationships seek balance**
   We prefer our likes and dislikes to fit together, and feel tension when they don't.[2]

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THE FRAMEWORK

Attribution and Balance[2]

Two of Heider's ideas still used everywhere from design to diplomacy.[2]

1 Attribution

Person or situation?

We explain behavior by something inside a person (traits, motives) or outside (circumstances), and over-weight the inside for others.[2,3]

Try: Before judging, list situational reasons.

2 Balance

We like consistency

My friend's friend should be my friend. When a relationship triangle is out of balance, we feel pressure to fix it.[2]

Try: Map the triangle to see what's really in tension.

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FROM THE BOOK

Tools to try

The attribution flip

Applying Heider's attribution idea.[2,3]

1. Write your explanation of someone's annoying behavior.
2. Write three situational explanations.
3. Act on the most charitable one that's still plausible.
4. Then ask, don't assume.

The balance triangle

Applying Heider's balance idea.[2]

1. Draw a triangle: you, another person, and an issue.
2. Mark each link + or −.
3. Find the link causing tension, and decide whether to change a view or accept the difference.

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MAKE IT YOURS

Try it this week

1. Notice one moment you judge someone's character.
2. Do the attribution flip.
3. Draw one balance triangle for a relationship that feels tense.
4. Have one conversation based on what you find.

REFLECT

Whose behavior have you been explaining by character rather than circumstance?

Which relationship triangle feels out of balance?

Try it in Sedi: Write the reflection as a private note in Brainly, and add the conversation as a task in Taskly.

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READ THE BOOK

🤝 The Psychology of Interpersonal Relations

Fritz Heider · John Wiley & Sons · 1958

This guide only scratches the surface. The book has the research, the stories and the nuance behind every idea here. Buy it from an independent bookshop, borrow it from your library, or listen to the audiobook.

A NOTE FROM ME

I'm not affiliated with Fritz Heider or the publisher, and this guide isn't sponsored or endorsed by them. I've learned a lot from this book, so I'm sharing what I took from it, for free, in case it helps you too. Everything here is my own summary, in my own words. The good ideas are the author's; any mistakes are mine.

The maker of Sedi

SOURCES

1. Heider, Fritz. *The Psychology of Interpersonal Relations*. John Wiley & Sons, 1958.
2. Wikipedia, "Fritz Heider". en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fritz_Heider
3. Ross, L. (1977). The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings. In L. Berkowitz (Ed.), *Advances in Experimental Social Psychology* (Vol. 10, pp. 173–220). Academic Press.
4. Heider, F., & Simmel, M. (1944). An experimental study of apparent behavior. *American Journal of Psychology*, 57(2), 243–259.